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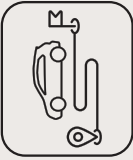


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From Coach to Manish Malhotra, designers are reimagining the fringe as a sculptural, movement-driven statement **P4**

metroPLUS THE  HINDU

With The Collectables, Mayyur Girotra transforms rare finds – from Rabari camel bags to vintage Kutch bedspreads – into luxury heirlooms, and advocates for their artisans

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pick of the week



Food for thought

Would you like to feast on dishes from before the time the Radcliffe Line was drawn? Head to Chennai's The New Punjab Club for Undivided Panjab dining experience, which offers chicken atishi seekh kebab, paneer sandwich pasanda, dhaba-style stuffed mushroom, and more.

Available till March 22 (Monday to Thursday: noon to 11pm; Friday to Sunday: noon to midnight). A meal for two costs ₹1,800. For reservations, call 9500947295



Bling it on

Adaia Diamonds, Chennai-based lab grown jewellery label, has launched The Couture collection, sculpted in 18K recycled gold and lab-grown diamonds in Champagne, blush and ivory tones. Inspired by Scandinavian minimalism, the edit's architectural lines echo the geometry seen in the works of Japanese architect Tadao Ando.

Starting at ₹5 lakh, the edit is available at Adaia Diamonds, 3rd Street, Abhiramapuram, Chennai.



Rapturous sonata

If western classical music, especially Beethoven, interests you, reserve March 18 for a concert by Madras Musical Association and the South Asian Symphony Foundation featuring cellist Raman Ramakrishnan and pianist Stephen Prutsman. They will perform three Beethoven sonatas at Museum Theatre, Egmore, Chennai. Tickets start at ₹500 on BookMyShow, at Etude School of Music, PMA School of Music, Musee Musical and MMA Chorister.



Funny side up!

Recognised among Asia's Top 10 comedians, Singapore's only full-time female comedian Sharul Channa will perform her latest show, Saree, These Are Just Jokes, in Chennai on March 14 at Punch. The gig will be peppered with Sharul's fearless takes on identity, relationships, gender expectations, and everyday social contradictions. For this tour, Sharul has collaborated with women-led sari brand Suta.

8pm onwards; tickets start at ₹499 on TheTicket9.com

Karan Gokani

I didn't enter hospitality the traditional way. I arrived sideways, from law. From a world of documents, structure and certainty into one that looked, from the outside, joyful, chaotic and alive. Energy, bustle, creativity, smiles and delicious food landing on tables and changing the mood of a room. I adored it from afar.

From the inside, I can safely say, I love it even more.

The graft, sore legs, late nights, unexpected challenges each day and everything that comes with it.

Which is why I'm strangely calm about AI.

There's a lot of hand-wringing about it, and a lot of breathless optimism too. As ever, the truth sits somewhere in the middle. AI is neither the saviour nor the villain of hospitality. It's a pressure multiplier and this industry is already under a great deal of pressure.

In the UK we're operating in a moment of growing protectionism. Borders tightening. Visas being denied overnight. Immigrants being targeted, ostracised and, in some cases, outright banned. Hospitality has always depended on movement of people, ideas and cultures and sadly that flow is slowing.

You see it most clearly in kitchens and dining rooms. The Italians, who once quietly ran the junior rungs of London hospitality, have largely disappeared. Eastern Europeans, who chose to stay on through a harder climate and tougher economy, are now in huge demand, stretched thin.

Asian visas, in many cases, simply stopped.

All of this has created enormous strain. Staff costs are staggering. Hiring is painful. Fewer people want the physical grind, the unsociable hours, the repetition. Many want to work from home. Hospitality, by



GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK

AT THE TABLE

Can a robot serve dinner?

AI is neither the saviour nor villain of hospitality. It's a pressure multiplier

definition, cannot. Similar challenges persist in the industry across the world. I know enough restaurateur friends in India, who are holding

house (BOH) admin is the first casualty. Cost control, forecasting, finance, marketing roles that once required teams now sit quietly inside software. Robots will take over menial BOH tasks once the hardware catches up, and it will; sooner than we think. It will be a matter of months at the rate things are moving. Front of house, though, is where my predictions get more nuanced. In all but the highest levels of dining, many tasks will disappear or be heavily streamlined. Computerised ordering will become standard and highly personalised. Runners may be replaced. Service lines simplified. Efficiency will be engineered in, whether we like it or not.

But hospitality doesn't live in these tasks, it lives in the humans that frame your restaurant journey. AI will never replace that smile at the door, the warmth of being recognised, remembered,

cared for. The quiet intelligence of reading a table, knowing when to step in and when to step back. The chef who creates from a personal journey, not a dataset. The waiter who makes you feel like an old friend guiding you on a journey of discovery.

Much like theatre has come to be more valued in a world of Netflix and streaming, these personal experiences won't disappear, they'll become more coveted. In a world of AI and robots, people will come to crave them specifically because they are human, occasionally imperfect and impossible to automate.

Restaurants were created to restore people. To slow the pace, to offer refuge and in a frantic world where the rats are replaced by robots and the race only accelerates, that need for restoration will deepen. My fear isn't that AI replaces hospitality. It's that protectionism, short-term thinking and exhaustion hollow it out before we realise what we're losing. I see AI as a tool that, used well, gives hospitality back its soul. If machines take care of the admin, the repetition and the noise, then humans can focus on what they do best: welcoming, cooking, caring, hosting.

Which brings me back to why I left law in the first place.

I didn't switch careers because hospitality was easier. It isn't. I switched because it felt alive. Because at its best, it's generous, emotional and deeply human.

And the more automated the world becomes, the more I believe people will seek out places where that humanity is not just present, but protected.

From the outside, hospitality looked like joy.

From the inside, it turns out that joy lies in its humanity.

And that's exactly why it will last.

Karan Gokani is a London-based chef and restaurateur who spends his time cooking, travelling and exploring what the world is eating. He loves the gym, biriyani and his frying pan. Not necessarily in that order.



The GI-tagged playground

Cavity, a new cocktail bar in Delhi, offers a nine-course experience featuring regional dishes from across India. We drink warm Amazake with a bheja custard truffle tart

Deepali Dhingra

While the world upstairs at Barbet & Pals thrives on high-energy music and clinking of glasses, we follow the chirping Barbet as it hops down into the secret hollow, for mellow music and intimate conversations.

There might be some irony in naming the city's new cocktail bar Cavity. Far from a void, it is a place that fills the senses. Its nine-course narrative, helmed

by co-founders Jeet Rana and Chirag Pal, is rooted in the culinary vision of Chef Amninder Sandhu.

The cosy space, reminiscent of a living room in the hills, has an intimate area with a stainless-steel bar top table and nine comfortable bar chairs surrounding it.

"We wanted to celebrate the GI-tagged ingredients of India, but we also want to have fun with flavour combinations and techniques," says Jeet.

Amninder's philosophy is clear: the food is a "burst of



feeling," designed to support the cocktails.

Our journey begins with mead – a floral drink made with fermented honey from the Sundarbans. The sweetness is introduced via a whimsical tuft of cherry-scented cotton candy hiding a savoury liver pate inside.

We devour tor toast with sardine-like fish found in Uttarakhand, which is perched on walnut milk bread; and bedu, fig and cheese served with parmesan crisp and puffed Manipuri black rice.

Then comes Amazake, a warm drink made with fermented joha rice from Assam and flavoured with passion fruit for a creamy, tropical brightness. It is accompanied by kaddoo, a fritter-style prawn balchao stuffed pumpkin flower, which is spicy, creamy

and crunchy, all at once.

Hot & Cold arrives in a double-wall glass and makes use of tooyamalli rice foam with clarified rasam and whisky in a hot and cold combination. Served with it is pepper crab idli with gunpowder, coconut chutney and caviar.

The Susegad, with sour mango and coconut slushy is probably the least of our favourites – something about its texture feels like a discord – and we focus instead on truffle, a bheja custard tart with sour cherry jam and black truffle shavings which Amninder generously grates on the bite-sized offering.

It tastes like a savoury dessert – salty, earthy, and tart all at once – the kind of dish that makes you pause, look at your companion, and say, "I can't believe that was bheja!"

With the ABV set to increase with the next set of drinks, mixologists ensure the guests stay hydrated with a combination of coconut water

We wanted to celebrate the GI-tagged ingredients of India but we also want to have fun with the flavour combinations and techniques.

JEET RANA
Co-founder, Cavity

and electrolytes. As the soundtrack shifts from the soulful strumming of 'Harvest Moon' to the dramatic swell of 'November Rain', guests are reminded that this menu is ever-changing. The honey might change from the mangroves of the East to the mustard flowers of Punjab; the rice might swap for a millet.

"The structure will remain the same but we intend to play with it in order to bring other ingredients in focus," says Jeet.

The next three drinks vie for our attention, but between the umami and spicy tequila-based Guntur chilli chicken made with chicken chilli consommé, the gin-based Gibson with the sweetness of Ladakhi apricot, and the smoky and sweet Gimlet with black cardamom, whisky and mezcal, it is tough to pick a favourite. Amninder elevates these drinks with a velvety bone marrow custard-stuffed zarai cheese gurgere, a meaty bhutwa seekh served with Amritsari kulcha and charred tomato ice cream, and nihari – slow-braised kareli (cut from leg of goat) in gravy along with saffron-scented buttery bread, a tasty savoury base with the smoky Gimlet. Somewhere in the middle, we also slurp on a banana chuski made with Assam's Bhimkol banana.

As the evening winds down with a tribute to Baba Budan – a Coorg coffee-amaro, Amninder places a dish called nolen gur on the table with different textures of the liquid gold from Bengal.

It is sophisticated, earthy and brings the night to a refined end, but not before we sweeten the night a little further with mini brown butter softies.

Finally, Cavity feels like a rare, quiet moment in the middle of the capital where the stories of the land finally get the stage they deserve.

Cavity is at Ground Floor, M-51, Block M, Greater Kailash II. It is open on Friday, Saturday and Sunday at 8pm. A meal for two costs ₹4,500. For reservations call 9205645151



Textural symphony

A cool colour palette, which ranges from soft pastels, ivories, vintage pink, blush, and sage, comes to define Label Niti Bothra's latest Spring/Summer '26 collection called Vaayu Pret. It spotlights a luxurious blend of natural silk and mercerised cotton, textured with raised checks and subtle stripes. Within this canvas, appliqué emerges as a language of quiet craftsmanship.

Delicate pearl and resham embroidery form the base, which is further layered with fine hand detailing of aari dori embroidery, pearl and kardana tassels and floral organza cut-outs.

Starting at ₹17,990, the collection is available on the brand's website as well as at prominent multi-brand stores such as Ogaan, Aza, Pernia's Pop-Up Shop, and Ensemble.



Manish Mishra

After seasons of stark minimalism and a quiet luxury approach to dressing, the fun and flirty fringe is now enjoying the spotlight: as seen at the recently concluded New York and London Fashion Week, and also on the BAFTA red carpet where Nigerian-British actor Wunmi Mosaku sported a cobalt blue one-shoulder gown with dramatic fringe detailing by British designer Priya Ahluwalia. More recently, Angelina Jolie's red carpet return for her latest film *Couture's* premiere in Paris had her in an ankle-length nude mesh dress festooned in silver sequined flowers and beaded fringe.

At the New York Fashion Week Fall Winter 2026-27 showcase, Proenza Schouler's artistic director Rachel Scott reimagined the house's signature fringe sending out half-cut fringe across a series of finale gowns. At the London Fashion Week, Burberry played with sparkly fringe which was crafted to evoke streaks of rain seen across evening dresses, tailored coats and skirts. Moreover, fringe also appeared at Coach, Ralph Lauren and Erdem who extrapolated it in their distinctive handwriting.

Indian designers like Manish Malhotra and Kresha Bajaj experimented with fringe with a decidedly maximalist approach at the recently-concluded Dubai Fashion Week. Manish presented his showstopper Kriti Sanon in a pearl-trimmed ensemble and Kresha's evening dresses came alive with metallic tassels which swished and whooshed as her models glided past the runway.

Manish sees fringes and tassels becoming more fluid and refined. The designer who recently used them in his Inaya collection,

predicts them evolving in lighter, more elegant ways. "Less heavy, more movement-driven, almost like jewellery in motion," he says.

Let fringe be the hero

Manish suggests keeping the rest of the look clean and balanced, and let the fringes be the hero. "Even when they're not the main focus, they work beautifully in complementing an outfit – adding movement and texture," he adds.

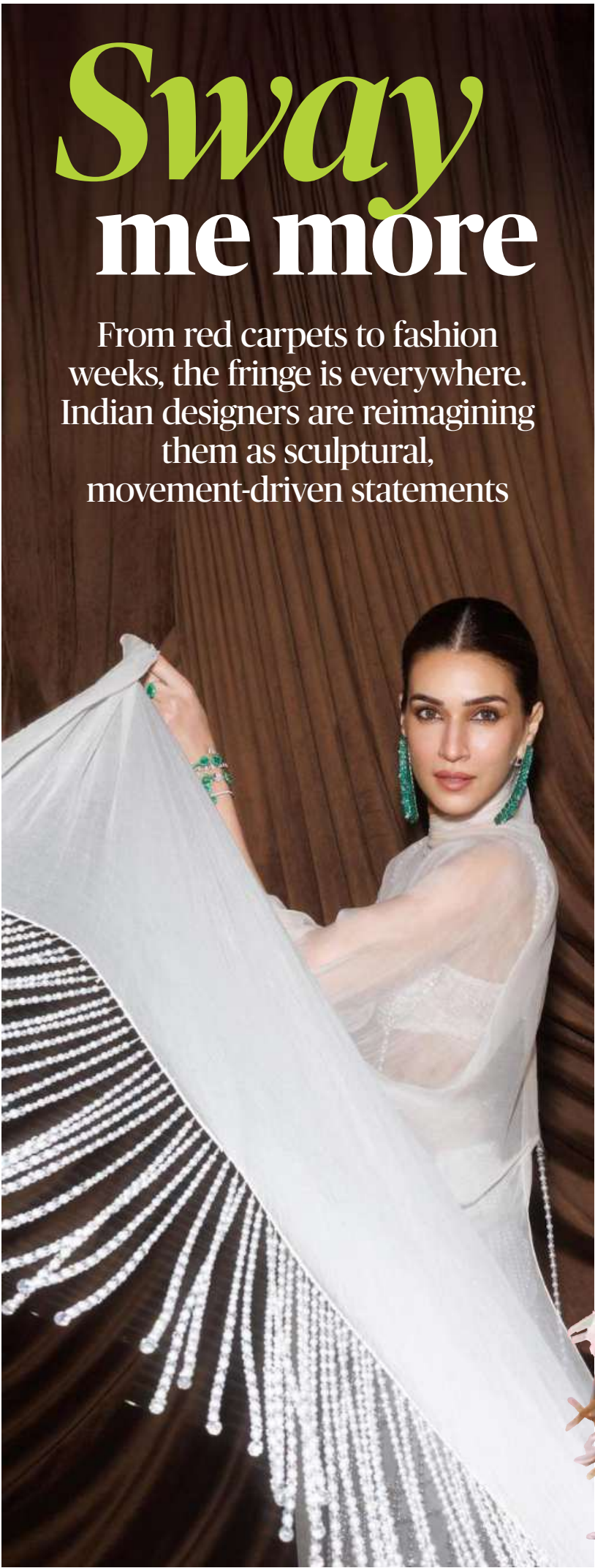
The key is styling them smartly. Pair them with minimal jewellery and modern silhouettes so the fringes feel effortless, elegant and never overpowering. Kresha seconds that. "If you're wearing a strong fringe piece, let it be the protagonist. Keep the rest clean. Sharp hair, minimal jewellery, confident footwear," she says.

The drama should come from how the garment reacts to your body, adds Kresha. "For bridal wear, a corseted blouse with tonal bead fringe worn with a clean lehenga feels modern without being overwhelming. And for evening wear, metal or mirror fringe works beautifully with monochrome styling. Let the texture catch the light instead of adding colour chaos," she notes.

And most importantly, fringe and tassels need space. It needs air. "Don't overcrowd it with layering unless the intention is maximalist. Let it move. That's where its power lies," she suggests.

Not just embellishments

Fringe has evolved from being just a decorative movement. In fact, it is shaping up to become a structure. Kresha observes that tassels were earlier used to soften a look or add fluidity. Now, they are being given a playful treatment in a wide array of materials like metals and leather. "You'll see metal fringes, mirror



Sway me more

From red carpets to fashion weeks, the fringe is everywhere. Indian designers are reimagining them as sculptural, movement-driven statements



(Clockwise from left) Outfits by Manish Malhotra; from Chanel's Spring-Summer 2026 collection; Rohit Gandhi + Rahul Khanna's take on fringe; another outfit by Chanel; and actor Kriti Sanon in a creation by Manish Malhotra. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

strips, leather corded tassels, even beaded strands that behave almost like armour. It's less flirty, more powerful," she says.

Kresha says she anticipates upcoming collections using fringe will be layered, denser, sometimes tonal, and also sharply contrasted at times so it feels graphic. Another big shift is placement. Instead of the obvious hemlines, you'll see fringe

defining shoulders, cutting across corsetry, tracing the spine, or forming sculptural capes," she adds.

A study of movement

Designer Rahul Khanna of label Rohit Gandhi + Rahul Khanna points out that fringe has never been an embellishment for the design house but a study of movement against structure. "In 2026, we see it becoming more architectural, less bohemian and more deliberate," says Rahul.

The emphasis is shifting from excess to precision. Fringes or tassels are no longer just

employed to amp up the drama but to lend garments a vibrant finish.

Designers like Simone Rocha and Erdem have integrated fringe into lace, tulle and jacquard thus blurring the line between embroidery, weave and fringe. Even while referencing western-inspired fringe, brands like Coach are refining it into cleaner cuts and sharper silhouettes. Moreover, fringe has also become a vessel for sustainable storytelling with brands like Ahluwalia (helmed by Priya Ahluwalia) employing upcycled fringe from fabric waste.

Fringe has come a long way – from being a synonym of the Jazz Age, to being a modern artisanal texture used by global brands and celebrity stylists for layered storytelling and craft-led innovation. It would be interesting to see how this fashion's favourite insignia evolves in the coming season.



(Clockwise from left) On the day The Collectables launched, the Imam of Jama Masjid along with the designer hosted iftar, where guests wore Mayyur Girotra; Mayyur with weavers in Barmer, Rajasthan; Shoba De in a patola sari by the designer; the new range. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT AND GAYATRI NAIR



textiles on the global stage is not enough, if we are taking undue advantage of the skills of our artisans."

He explains how he now sells not just the work but also the process. He also advocated for fair pay, starting by setting an example himself. "Designers have to give them the right value for the product they are creating. Even if it means cutting from your very, very high margins." He adds, "I will make sure that whatever money comes to us is also going to them, to their kids. We don't want their kids to be scared of holding those looms."

Finding modern uses for century-old crafts and textiles is also a practical way to ensure they survive. The Collectables is built around rare and historic finds sourced from all over the world. They are studied and then reimagined into couture, blending techniques, textiles and design languages. Mayyur and his team work with women in Barmer, Rajasthan, alongside traditional weavers and

small artisan communities for this, often spending two to three months on a single jacket because of the intricacy of the work.

It is a necessarily limited collection.

The pieces are cinematic: A jacket shimmering with a layering of zardozi and gota, made from old, handcrafted dunki bags, the camel saddle bags carried by nomadic Rabaris across Rajasthan. An old Kutch bedcover from Udaipur that has been transformed into a biker jacket in deep shades of red, spangled with gold. A sari with black and white Madras checks, and a wide orange border from a Rabari shawl. "I just patched on the pallu. I haven't touched the old Rabari work because it is so beautiful and in such good condition," says Mayyur.

He holds up a trench coat with main character energy. "It was found in Tibet. This Pashtun embroidery is probably originally from Afghanistan, and you see it a lot in Pakistan now. We added hoof work, then layered it with gota. There is mul mul inside to give it life... How did it travel? I don't know," he shrugs, adding, "That whole emotional energy that comes with the garment is beautiful."

"These are made to become heirlooms. So it's there now, and it is going to be there forever. For your kids and whoever you pass it on to," says Mayyur, adding, "When you're wearing a piece, it holds so much, so many hands, so many regions, so much history. They are a storyline in your wardrobe."

The bohemian maximalist

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He beckons us closer to see the work on the lungi, which has had a signature Mayyur Girotra glow up. Now a sharply tailored waistcoat, the blue and grey checks, familiar to anyone who has loitered beside a chai stall, come from three handloom lungis from Tamil Nadu, Rajasthan and Gujarat. They are layered with Suzani-inspired running stitches, followed by dori work and kora zardozi. In today's luxury



landscape, often dominated by conformity and the quiet tyranny of trends, Mayyur's magpie-like enthusiasm for things he considers beautiful, and his crusade to save them is refreshing.

"What we call luxury and what we flaunt is made in very dark rooms," he says. "I was in Kanchipuram last week to collaborate with a weaver and

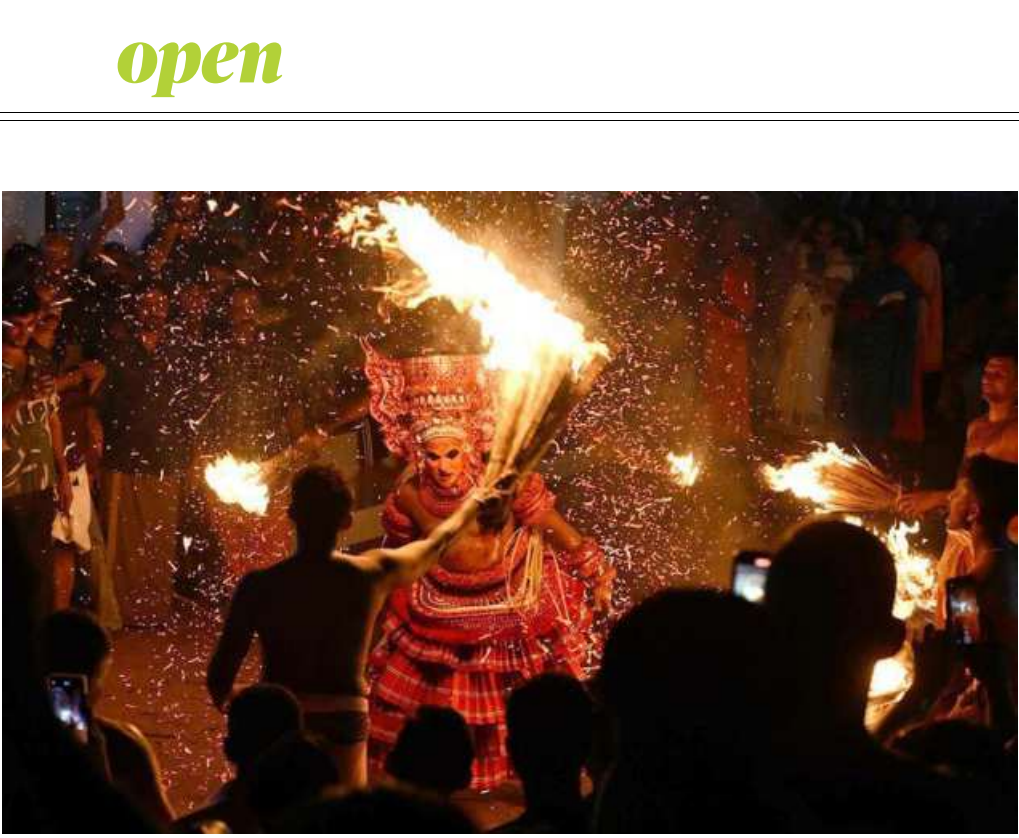
the power went off. He was sitting there, working and sweating." He pauses to fight back visible emotion. "We wear luxury couture, we wear Kanjeevarams that retail for lakhs. But what about the weaver, he is the mother to this craft. Just talking about bringing Indian

As the Theyyam season reaches its peak, here's how you can partake in curated experiences that offer a deeper engagement with Kerala's centuries-old folklore

On a Theyyam trail

Anasuya Menon
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Starting late October, when the Theyyam season begins, the sacred groves of northern Malabar stir to life. In these groves and ancestral family homes of Kannur and Kasaragod, Theyyam performances are an annual ritual. Performers in elaborate crimson gear blend movements of Kalaripayattu and dramatic fire rituals. Up until the season ends in May, the entire region of northern Malabar opens up – sharing its beliefs, heritage and storied legends with the world. Anyone – irrespective of caste, religion or nationality – can watch the performances and partake of the offerings at these shrines. It is this shared sense of community and connection with the land that travellers are increasingly seeking today. Tours, trails and packages tailor-made for curious travellers are increasingly available, offering a



(Clockwise from left) Kandanar Kelan Theyyam in Kannur; Veeranmaar Theyyam, Thuluvanam, Kasaragod; and Gulikan Theyyam in Kasaragod. THULASI KAKKAT

include visits to sacred groves, exploring bell metal workshops, where the ornaments, weapons and anklets of Theyyam artistes are made. Interactions with artistes, community elders, local food and visits to the historical Bekal Fort in Kasaragod, St. Angelo Fort in Kannur and Folklore Museum at Chirakkal are also part of the package. Approximately ₹7,500 per person, for a group of four participants. @ekathraexperiences on Instagram

Story time with Theyyam Tours
Thalassery-based Theyyam Tours was founded as a passion project in 2018 by Amogh PC. An ardent Theyyam enthusiast, he has been returning to his hometown every Theyyam season, even while pursuing his MTech in Computer Science Engineering from IIT Hyderabad. While interacting with tourists who came to watch Theyyam, he realised that even though they were spellbound by the colours and the stunts, few understood the stories behind the Theyyam or the significance of the costumes, gestures and rituals. “I enjoyed narrating the stories behind the Theyyam forms, and answering people’s questions,” he says, adding that he tied up with autorickshaw drivers who networked as local tourist guides to start an informal network. What started as a side hustle soon grew into a travel company in 2025, comprising Amogh, his brother Agin and their teammate Adithya. The two-day two-night package includes accommodation in a traditional Kerala Tharavad. During the day, the tourists would get an experience of Thalassery as well. The packages on offer are Divine Fiery Theyyams (from ₹9,999), Weekend Theyyam Experience (from ₹8,999) and Weekday Theyyam (from ₹8,499). @theyyamtours on Instagram



insight into the history of Theyyam and its socio-cultural relevance. “Currently 70% of our tourists are domestic,” says Manoj, who organises trails off-season as well. “During Karkidakam, when performances do not take place, we organise interactions with Theyyam artistes, who provide a deeper introduction to the myths and oral traditions. These sessions allow guests to engage directly with the performers and observe their elaborate costumes and ritual accoutrements up close,” he adds. Upwards of ₹3,500. @polika.life on Instagram

Ekathra Experiences' Theyyam ecosystem
The Theyyam tour is one of the most prominent among the 11

theme-based travel packages offered by Ekathra Experiences, a conservation-oriented travel company based in Kozhikode. “While the Theyyam is, to the traveller, a grand visual display, it has multiple layers to it,” says founder Sreejith Payyadakath. “Beyond the visual aspect, the social context of Theyyam is interesting to the traveller. Traditionally performed by members of marginalised communities, Theyyam inverts established caste hierarchies. The performer becomes the deity that everyone worships,” Sreejith explains. The sustainability aspect is another factor that sets it apart, he adds. “Many of the sacred groves exist

today because of Theyyams. They have been protected for generations, not by environmental laws, but stories, rituals and taboos.” Ekathra's packages are for two days and one night, which



(Clockwise from below) Two models sporting jhumka-style earrings from Polo Ralph Lauren Fall Winter 26-27 women's collection; Perna Rajpal; rodeo-inspired pieces featuring equestrian elements from Polo Ralph Lauren's recent collection; and Siddhartha Totuka. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

After Ralph Lauren showcased jhumka-style earrings at Paris Fashion Week, describing them as “vintage accessories”, critics questioned the absence of South Asian attribution

Manish Mishra

Ralph Lauren was in the line of fire at the Paris Fashion Week, held between March 2 and March 10, after models sashayed down the runway sporting jhumka-style earrings from its Polo Ralph Lauren Fall/Winter 26-27 women's collection. The luxury brand described the earpieces as “vintage accessories”, without making any reference to their South Asian origin. As expected, the jhumkas elicited a fusillade of comments and debates across social media platforms. The bell-shaped earrings, from silver domes to exaggerated beaded drops, were paired with rodeo-inspired pieces featuring equestrian elements like fringe suede jacket, patch pocket denims and saddlery bags. On Instagram, the brand wrote, “Featuring vintage accessories and select pieces crafted by Native American designers Neil Zarama, Jimmy Begay, and TÓPA as part of Ralph Lauren's Authentic Makers and Artist in Residence programs.” The caption on one of its posts read, “Select looks are styled with authentic vintage accessories.”

History of jhumkas
According to caratlane.com and other fine jewellery websites, jhumkas originated in India around



All ears!

300 BC, initially synonymous with temple deities. A synonym for femininity, they evolved from South Indian temple jewellery. The earliest jhumkas, found in Chola temple sculptures in South India, were crafted from gold and were later popularised by temple dancers. Later, from 1526-1857, Mughals reimagined the design with pearls and diamonds.

Global appeal
In the 1920s, Cartier adapted the jhumka design, lending it a more western, elevated look. In the 1990s, Fred Leighton crafted chandelier or dangling earrings described as a westernised, two-dimensional version of the traditional 3D jhumka. LA-based jeweller Sophie Buhai unveiled “\$850 ‘Nadia’ earrings” inspired by traditional Indian artistry. Also, luxury brands Jean Paul Gaultier, Hermès, and Yves Saint Laurent have drawn from various global, traditional, and ethnic jewellery styles, including forms similar to jhumkas. Nitin Goenka, founder, Goenka



India, a diamantaire and jeweller, shares, “While global fashion often draws inspiration from diverse cultures, it is important that such influences are acknowledged with sensitivity and proper historical context. Presenting jhumkas merely as ‘vintage accessories’ risks overlooking their deep cultural, religious, and historical significance. Recognising their origins not only honours the craftsmanship and traditions of South Asian artisans but also encourages a more respectful and informed dialogue within the fashion industry about cultural

heritage and inspiration.” Nitin believes that jhumkas are not merely a stylistic motif but a deeply rooted element of Indian jewellery heritage. “When an object so strongly associated with a particular cultural identity is presented without context or attribution, it raises valid concerns about cultural acknowledgment and representation. In a globalised fashion landscape, where cross-cultural inspiration is inevitable, the issue is not the act of borrowing itself but the absence of credit. Recognising the Indian origins of jhumkas would not diminish the creativity of reinterpretation; rather, it would demonstrate respect for the rich heritage that have defined this form of jewellery for centuries,” he adds.

Absence of credit
Perna Rajpal, founder and CEO of fine jewellery brand Amaris, shares, “The issue isn’t that a western brand has drawn inspiration from jhumkas; cross-cultural borrowing in jewellery has existed for centuries. The real concern here is erasure through rebranding,” she says, adding, “When a brand like Ralph Lauren presents the same form as a generic ‘vintage bell earring,’ it detaches the design from its cultural lineage,” she adds. Fashion and jewellery constantly reinterpret global forms, and that exchange is part of how design evolves. “But when the origin of a design is clear and culturally specific, acknowledging that origin is both respectful and intellectually honest. Recognition doesn’t limit creativity, it actually enriches the narrative around the piece,” says Perna. Akanksha Arora, CEO of Tribe Amrapali, says, “It’s amazing to see Indian jhumkas appearing on global runways, as it reflects the timeless appeal of our jewellery traditions. While fashion has always thrived on cross-cultural inspirations, it is important to acknowledge where these designs originate from. Jhumkas are deeply rooted in India’s cultural and craft heritage, and giving credit to that legacy helps preserve and

respect the traditions behind them. At times, creativity can naturally lead to similar interpretations of forms and silhouettes. What matters is approaching such inspirations with awareness and respect”. Siddhartha Totuka, director, PC Totuka & Sons, a fine jewellery brand, shares, “Borrowing across cultures is how design has always moved through the world. The issue isn’t inspiration.



It’s silence. When something rooted in a particular people and place is lifted without a glance backward, something gets lost not legally, perhaps, but in terms of integrity. To name where something comes from is to acknowledge the hands that made it and carried it forward across generations. In a moment when cultural identity is no longer a peripheral conversation, that acknowledgement isn’t a footnote.”

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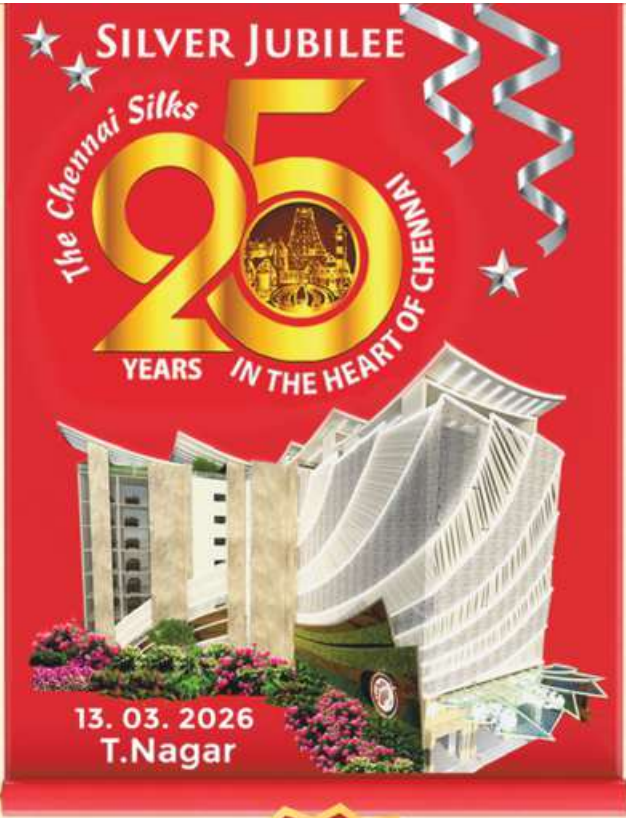
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Telugu

A partly engaging crime drama



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Mrithyunjay, the Telugu film written and directed by Hussain Sha Kiran and led by Sree Vishnu is designed as an investigative thriller, and builds intrigue in parts. A few smart stretches, however, are undercut by convenient writing choices that keep the film from becoming fully engaging.

On the positive side, *Mrithyunjay* stays focused on its core story and characters. It avoids needless frills. The comedy is situational and blends smoothly into the narrative, and the film resists forcing in a romantic track. Sree Vishnu plays Jay, an aspiring crime reporter, while Reba Monica John appears as Sita, a police officer. Their paths cross solely during the investigation.

Mrithyunjay assumes its viewers will not ask too many practical questions. Jay is introduced as a chameleon who slips into different avatars and uses sharp observation skills to outsmart any gathering. His job is to secure obituary ads for a newspaper. He visits mourning households, poses as an acquaintance of the deceased and persuades families to publish heartfelt obituaries. People pool in money and he meets his targets.

Anyone familiar with how mainstream newspapers function will know that securing ads is the domain of marketing teams, not reporters. The film blurs these roles, with Jay repeatedly pleading with his boss and a senior reporter to let him join the crime bureau.

When two deaths in the city, initially seen as freak accidents, occur, Jay, who visits the families for obituary ads, suspects foul play. The narrative ties his determination to the trauma of a young girl and echoes of his own troubled childhood.

The story contains intriguing elements: a bank scam, contract killers and murders staged as accidents. Yet while the film focuses on Jay's dogged pursuit of the truth, the police remain largely peripheral. Even Sita, who is meant to be resolute in seeking answers, does not do enough to push the investigation forward.

Despite these gaps, the stretches leading to Jay crossing paths with the killer generate some intrigue. The ensuing cat-and-mouse game avoids predictability. The film positions Jay and the killer as formidable adversaries. Their mind games and chases work in parts, though several loopholes are hard to ignore.

A few smaller details work in the film's favour: Jay's bond with his aunt and his attempt to find closure for his own childhood trauma by helping the young girl. The title refers not only to one who conquers death but also juxtaposes *mrithyu* (death) and Jay (victory). The subtext, however, is spelled out rather than allowed to unfold subtly.

Mrithyunjay remains intermittently intriguing but never quite realises its potential to become a standout crime drama.

Mrithyunjay is currently playing in theatres



An affecting rumination on guilt

Despite a few contrivances, a reflective psychological core powers this restrained thriller drama starring Nivedhithaa Sathish, Ciby, Attul and Nasser

Tamil

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Does everything happen by design or destiny? Do all actions have a cause and an effect? If something as negligible as a butterfly flapping its wings can, in theory, cause a tornado, do all things have a similar, seemingly unrelated, minuscule cause? And if so, can you somehow be the cause of something so big? If so, can anything and everything you do result in something catastrophic? An inquiry into the Butterfly Effect seems like an intriguing exercise, though the tone can turn drastically if the tornado caused by the butterfly upends your life, or rather, if you were the butterfly that caused a tornado. A hapless victim of fate gets imprisoned in this line of thought in *Oh Butterfly*, a two-hour rumination on guilt directed by debutant Vijay Ranganathan.

In the long, sleepless eyes of Gowri (played with excellent control by Nivedhithaa Sathish), we see a woman lost to the storms of life. She tells her newly-employed maid about how she suffers from a condition that prevents her from being in the same room as her, and we are soon shown what precisely happens to Gowri should she attempt to break this self-imposed constraint. Suffering from extreme Harm OCD as a result of the death of her husband, Gowri's mind restlessly conjures scenarios of how her mundane actions could hurt others. For instance, the thought of helping the maid in the kitchen brings up scenarios through which she inadvertently plunges a kitchen knife into her throat. What caused this extreme paranoia in Gowri is what we interrogate as her spiritualist sister, Ranjani (Lakshmi Priya Chandramouli), helps her open up. Right off the bat, the introduction to

Oh Butterfly

Director: Vijay Ranganathan

Cast: Nivedhithaa Sathish, Ciby, Attul and Nasser

Storyline: The sudden arrival of her ex-lover creates chaos in the lives of a newly married couple



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this world sets up the tone and temperature that director Vijay impressively maintains throughout the film. The main narrative of the film begins some 40-odd hours before the death of Arjun (Attul), Gowri's husband, as they enter their Kurinji summer home in Kodaikanal – placards of the hours before the inevitable death act as the ticking time bomb that helps us track the time and thereby the urgency of the proceedings.

Gowri, we realise, has brought Arjun on vacation to confess something she had been hoping to ever since their wedding four months ago. Just as she is about to broach the topic, Gowri gets the shock of her life when Suriya (Ciby) – Arjun's college friend, who, unbeknownst to the former, is also Gowri's ex-lover who once betrayed her – makes a surprise appearance. A lean and effective thriller that compels your attention follows.

Character-writing is the biggest strength of *Oh Butterfly* as Gowri, Arjun and Suriya all immediately strike a chord as people we might have come across at some point in our lives. The writing of Arjun, especially, is a tight-rope walk since this is an ever-anxious, hair-trigger-tempered, miserable man who is meant to both evoke pity and get under your skin. Unfairly fired from his job, Arjun is desperately looking for funding for a new start-up that is ready to take him in. The moment Suriya enters, Arjun believes that they were destined to meet and suspends everything at a moment's notice, assuming Suriya would serve his cause. At the same time, the lack of chemistry in his marriage is becoming a cause of stress. He shuttles between extreme emotional poles so quickly, and writer-director Vijay finds in Arjun a nervous child who goes to any lengths to feel a win.

Meanwhile, Ciby manages to come across as a man you are always wary of for some unexplained reason. Suriya appears harmless and even carries a free-spirited hippie energy, and yet everything he says feels quietly caustic.

And stuck between these two cut-outs of fractured masculinity is Gowri, who spirals in guilt as a helpless spectator.

However, the characters who would truly leave a mark and elevate *Oh Butterfly* to a deeply philosophical space are those of Sagayam (the ever-impressive Nasser) – the home's caretaker and an oddball butterfly-breeder who somehow can smell death when it is right around the corner – and his newborn butterfly Jebamani. Much of what Sagayam utters (though sometimes seeming like expository philosophising) stays with you, like a dialogue about what matters in a lifetime that spans only 15 days. The butterfly, on the other hand, becomes an allegory to Gowri herself, and what many of us like Gowri fail to see about our short lives.

Writer-director Vijay shows a great knack for writing metaphors and motifs. A golf ball for instance, becomes both a liberator and a destructor. Similarly, the use of composer Vaisakh Somanath's superb compositions adds to the very specific atmosphere the director has opted for. Also deserving of credit are the performers; given that much of the film revolves around three or four characters, a lot rests on the shoulders of the leads, and they ace it with ease. How great it is to see veteran actor Nasser in roles like these; even with his relatively short screentime, he makes his presence felt effortlessly.

Sure, there are contrivances, like a moment towards the end that is about Suriya, or how the arc about Soda Buddi Kezhavi, an astrologer played by Geetha Kailasam, ends. But *Oh Butterfly* isn't desperate to impress. As the well-cut trailer revealed, it is a film aware of its scale and ambition. And at a time when Tamil films seem too eager to achieve greater heights, this is a film that manages to stir something strong in you by merely flapping its wings and seems all the more content with the heights it soars.

Oh Butterfly releases in theatres on March 6, Friday

Anil Kapoor's angsty intensity lifts this action drama

Hindi

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The rank of Subedar evokes humble authority in the Hindi heartland. As the army's backbone, these quiet mainstays, often drawn from the subaltern classes, are more respected than idolised. Anil Kapoor's status in Hindi cinema is similarly earned. The analogy finds shape in director Suresh Triveni's emotionally charged action drama, with the repurposed folksy number "Balam Subedar" underlining the title's regional draw, where a culture of entitlement is pervasive.

Set amidst the illegal sand mafia that is fast changing the shape of our rivers and social ecosystem, *Subedar* follows the reluctant rise of retired junior commissioned officer Arjun Maurya against a ruthless syndicate. This central conflict anchors the film's exploration of power and resistance.



Haunted by the tragic death of his wife Sudha (Khushboo Sundar), Arjun wrestles with civilian disillusionment, suppressed anger, and a strained relationship with his daughter Shyama (Radhikka Madan).

Looking for stability, Arjun takes a job through his loyal friend Prabhakar (Saurabh Shukla), which draws him into the circle of the illegal sand mining mafia led from prison by Babli Didi (Mona Singh), with her psychopathic stepbrother Prince (Aditya Rawal) and wily henchman Softy (Faisal Malik) enforcing control

through intimidation and violence.

The conflict escalates when provocations turn personal. Starting with poking fun at his background and age, it soon takes the shape of humiliation, and threats to his family. It triggers Arjun's transformation from a restrained, grieving veteran into a force of vigilante justice.

Powered by Anil Kapoor's smouldering, quietly intense presence, which echoes his vexed, brooding police inspector in *Thar* (2022), Arjun's internal conflict feels palpably authentic,

where a soldier's rigid military ethos bristles against the corrosive chaos of civilian corruption. Driven by deep-seated grief and guilt over his absentee fatherhood, this emotional core promises to lift the film beyond the confines of generic action fare.

The father-daughter relationship adds genuine emotional layers, delivering poignant moments of awkward silence, raw confrontation, and tentative reconnection. The triggers feel personal, and Arjun's righteous restraint aligns with the soldier archetype of discipline over rage.

However, after vividly building a tense, unnerving atmosphere on the scarred riverbanks, Triveni shuns the theme's rooted politics for big-screen flourish and falls back on tired tropes. He gets too focused on the Arjun-Prince track and loses sight of the bigger picture. While Aditya brings unhinged menace and Faisal is suitably wily, the narrative doesn't allow the stakes to grow. Meanwhile, Mona gets a short shrift as the appetising contest between Arjun and Babli bubbles out.

The subplots – Shyama's struggle

with college goons and Arjun's engagement with the community – feel tacked on and lack strong integration, which slows the story's momentum. As the climax unfolds, it first drags on and then abruptly accelerates past its own logic. Consequently, the emotional stakes never detonate fully, as if the filmmakers are deliberately saving some fireworks for a possible sequel.

Perhaps the form itself informs the film's dual voice. First, it immerses

you in the grim, grounded aesthetic of an unjust land – evocatively captured by cinematographer Ayan Saxena and Rohan Vinayak's compositions. But as you settle into this world, the makers seem to expect you to step back and appreciate a whistle-worthy Indianised Western starring Anil Kapoor as the retired badass. This tonal duality frames the viewing experience.

Ageing warhorses in Hollywood have famously extended their careers with this union of style and substance. However, whether it's the screen size or the execution, the shift in tone emerges as jarring in the film's second half. Despite an urgent theme and internalised performances, the film eventually bursts forth as a tribute to the 1980s action-hero formula, devoid of nuance.

Mostly watchable, but a little more guile, a little less hero worship would have made *Subedar* sahib proud.

Subedar is currently streaming on Amazon Prime.

Hoppers

Director: Daniel Chong

Voice cast: Piper Curda, Bobby Moynihan, Jon Hamm, Kathy Najimy, Dave Franco

Storyline: A fierce animal lover uses a new technology to converse with animals and save their habitat from greedy, self-serving humans



Big ideas and emotional beats

English

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In cinema logic, sharks, especially great whites, make excellent characters in animation. From Bruce in *Finding Nemo* to Mr Shark, the master of disguise in *The Bad Guys*, these apex predators turn their great gummy mouths with many pointy teeth into jolly good fellows.

In *Hoppers*, the 30th animation film from Pixar, there is a great white called Diane (Vanessa

Bayer), who, despite being a scary assassin, has such sweet, shining eyes and a warm smile that one cannot help but grinning back.

We first meet Mabel (Piper Curda) as a little girl trying to set all the animals in school free and being sent home for her pains (and also because she bites one of the teachers trying to stop her). Her busy mother drops Mabel with her grandmother (Karen Huie) who shows her the peace and quiet that can be hers if she only stops to listen.

The glade where grandmother Tanaka teaches her this valuable life lesson becomes a special place for Mabel. Years later, after her grandmother has passed, 19-year-old Mabel is a college student and still fighting for animal rights.

Matters come to a head when the mayor of Beaverton, Jerry Generazzo (Jon Hamm) plans to blow up the glade to build a freeway. Mabel tries to get signatures from the citizenry to stop the freeway plans, but that comes to naught as people quickly turn away from the zealous Mabel.

Frustrated, with no recourse

in sight, Mabel chances upon a beaver making its way to her university's biology lab. First worried that her biology professor Sam (Kathy Najimy) is doing some unspeakable animal experiments, Mabel is nonplussed to find that Sam, with her colleague Nisha (Aparna Nancherla) and graduate student Conner (Sam Richardson), have developed a revolutionary technology to transfer human consciousness to robot animal.

Mabel uploads her consciousness into a robot beaver and sets off to thwart the mayor. Seeing the world from the animals' perspective gives Mabel a unique point of view. *Hoppers* has jokes, chases, largeness of heart and solid science – not consciousness-switching with robot animals or flying shark assassins but the fact that beavers are the environmental engineers of the natural world.

The voice cast is wonderful, from Bobby Moynihan as the beaver king, George to Dave Franco as Titus, the prickly butterfly who becomes the insect king after Mabel accidentally kills his mum – the Insect Queen,

played with terrifying grandeur by Meryl Streep.

The animals are delightfully delineated, from the spaced-out beaver, Loaf (Eduardo Franco) to Ellen (Melissa Villaseñor) the grumpy bear. The animation is lovely, with each of the animal and human characteristics clearly outlined. From the mayor's grasping to Sam's brilliance, Mabel's fervour to Loaf's stillness, and the different animal monarchs' regality, it is all given marvellous life.

The “pond rules” ensure that the animals are not completely anthropomorphised – a sticky point in animation films where carnivores and herbivores hang together without even a sneaky licking of lips!

Smart, funny, exciting, honest, and touching, *Hoppers* is the kind of film you can watch with the *bachcha* party and elders alike, with a happy grin. And then there is Diane of the red, red lips and sparkly white rotating teeth – yes, *Hoppers* boasts that level of detailing.

Hoppers is currently running in theatres

Snippets



Kantara actor Sapthami Gowda slams paparazzi

Kannada actor Sapthami Gowda has slammed paparazzi for posting pictures and videos of female artistes with “inappropriate angles and unnecessary zooms.” The actor, who was seen in the recently-released *The Rise of Ashoka*, took to social media to express her thoughts.

“Repeatedly, videos and photographs of female actors at public events are shot and circulated from inappropriate angles, with unnecessary zooms that focus on our bodies rather than our work.” Sapthami stressed that female actors find the act “disrespectful.”

“The behaviour, carried out by a few individuals, is disrespectful and unacceptable. We are here for our craft. We are here for our cinema,” she wrote.



Kara, Dhanush's next with Por Thozhil director, gets a release date

Tamil star Dhanush's upcoming film *Kara*, directed by Vignesh Raja of *Por Thozhil* fame, will release in theatres on April 30, the makers announced on March 2.

The makers unveiled a new poster of the film to announce the news. Details about the film's plot and cast remain unknown.

With *Kara*, Vignesh once again joins hands with his *Por Thozhil* writer Alfred Prakash. GV Prakash is the music composer for the movie, while Theni Eashwar has been roped in as the cinematographer. Sreejith Sarang serves as the editor. *Kara* is bankrolled by Ishari K Ganesh of Vels Film International.



Maamla Legal Hai: Season 2 gets release date

Season 2 of Ravi Kishan's courtroom comedy, *Maamla Legal Hai* finally has a release date. The Netflix series will be released on the platform on April 3, the makers announced on March 5.

Directed by Sameer Saxena and Rahul Pandey, the show also stars Nidhi Bisht, Naila Grewal, Anant Joshi and Anjum Batra with Kusha Kapila and Dinesh Lal Yadav joining the cast. It is written by Syed Shadan, Mohak Aneja and Tatsat Pandey, based on the characters and world created by Saurabh Khanna and Kunal Anejal.

The first season of the show was released on Netflix in 2024.



Maggie Gyllenhaal's Frankenstein

Jessie Buckley and Christian Bale spark a feral, fascinating chemistry, though even their undead romance struggles to animate this unruly feminist monster mash

English

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A goth-punk feminist revival of Mary Shelley refracted through noir fatalism, vaudevillian spectacle, and a lovers-on-the-run romance that echoes the outlaw mythology of Bonnie and Clyde sounds like the sort of delirious cinematic cocktail that could only thrive under the watch of a filmmaker eager to test the limits of studio indulgence. Maggie Gyllenhaal's *The Bride!* indeed begins with that spirit of gleeful overreach, hurling together the undead, gangsters, musical numbers, and a manifesto about female authorship with the manic enthusiasm of someone rummaging through a century of pop culture and literary memory at once. Yet, the experience of watching it involves a constant awareness of its fragility, because every new flourish is perched perilously on the edge of collapse, and the film repeatedly proves how difficult it is to sustain such a baroque assemblage without the seams giving way and the underlying machinery spilling into view.

The Bride! situates its monstrous romance in a stylised 1930s Chicago where mobsters dominate smoky restaurants, punk-jazz pulses through underground clubs, and the ghost of Mary Shelley hovers over events with a mischievous interest in rewriting her own literary legacy. Jessie Buckley appears first as Ida, a brash party girl whose confrontation with a gangster ends in a violent death that turns her into the perfect raw material for a lonely creature seeking companionship. Christian Bale's Frank, the century-old survivor of Victor Frankenstein's experiment, persuades a renegade scientist named Dr Euphronious, to resurrect the corpse and craft the partner he believes will end his wandering solitude.

The revived woman awakens without memory and gradually assumes the mantle of the Bride, while fragments of Shelley's spirit erupt through her consciousness in unsettling Tourettes-like

The Bride!

Director: Maggie Gyllenhaal

Cast: Jessie Buckley, Christian Bale, Penélope Cruz, Annette Bening, Peter Sarsgaard, Jake Gyllenhaal

Storyline: In 1930s Chicago, a scientist brings a murdered young woman back to life to be a companion for Frankenstein's monster.

bursts that transform her into a mouthpiece for rage, rebellion, and stray literary echoes. Their escape from Chicago evolves into a fugitive journey that stretches toward New York and beyond, while detectives pursue them and newspaper headlines mythologise their crimes, allowing the film to toggle between monster movie, gangster chase, and tragic romance.

Gyllenhaal constructs this world through a flamboyant collage of references that draw equally from Depression-era musicals, shadow-soaked noir, and the feverish iconography of gothic literature.

Sandy Powell's costumes mix period silhouettes with a punk vocabulary that allows the Bride to move through flapper dresses, fur stoles, and streaks of anarchic black makeup as if the 1930s had collided with a modern underground fashion show, while Lawrence Sher's cinematography bathes the film in a mixture of smoky chiaroscuro and theatrical spotlights that evoke the vintage tension of his work on Todd Phillips' *Joker* and its egregious sequel. And the hair and makeup design pushes the monster imagery toward something feral and glamorous at once, with Buckley's frizzed lightning-streaked hair and chemical black stains across her lips creating a visual signature that echoes Elsa Lanchester's iconic silhouette while dragging it into a contemporary register of rebellious self-display.

Buckley and Bale are the film's most persuasive anchors because they commit to the material with a conviction that rescues even the clumsiest passages from total implosion. Buckley's Bride becomes a vessel for violent mood swings and sudden eruptions of Shelley-inspired (and at times, Wollstonecraftian) rhetoric, and the script occasionally stumbles upon an intriguing idea when those eruptions resemble involuntary bursts of historical consciousness, as if a Victorian intellectual spirit were hijacking a modern rebel body in flashes of manic clarity. The actor throws herself into these moments with ferocious abandon, turning the Bride into a creature who oscillates between wounded curiosity and volcanic fury. There is also a peculiar twist of timing hovering over the film's reception,

because Buckley's ferocious performance arrives just as the Irish actor stands in the wake of major awards recognition for her delicate work in Chloe Zhao's *Hamnet*, which creates the curious oddity of her likely accepting an Oscar next week while this unruly monster romance lurches into theaters.

Bale responds with a surprisingly gentle portrait of Frank, shaping the monster as a shy cinephile who adores Hollywood musicals and moves through the world with a bashful earnestness that softens the grotesque prosthetics. His performance introduces a streak of tenderness that makes the relationship feel sincere, and the contrast between Buckley's explosiveness and Bale's mournful restraint generates a chemistry that elevates the film's emotional core beyond the mythic melancholy recently associated with Jacob Elordi's Oscar-nominated turn in Guillermo del Toro's lavish 2025 adaptation.

Despite these strengths, the film eventually becomes exhausting, partly because the script piles ideological declarations, grotesque violence, and flamboyant spectacle into a restless swirl that rarely clarifies its own intentions. Gyllenhaal's enthusiasm for camp and provocation radiates from nearly every frame, and the story wrestles with the idea of a woman confronted with relentless brutality cultivating a monster of her own in order to survive the world that created her suffering. The film expresses that impulse through sputtering dialogue, lurid visuals, and occasional dance sequences that feel like anarchic cabaret, yet the satirical impulse often dilutes the seriousness of the themes.

The Bride! fascinates even as it frustrates, and its messiness becomes inseparable from its strange charm. The ambition remains admirable, and the energy rarely dips, though the film is little more than a cadaver assembled from dazzling but incompatible parts. One can't help but recall how Ethan Hawke's Lorenz Hart (rightly) sneers in Richard Linklater's *Blue Moon*, “any title that feels the need for an exclamation point, you want to steer clear of.”

The Bride! is currently running in theatres